

Vardzia

A multitiered complex of caves carved into the mountainside to accommodate a monastery and the Church of the Dormition



In the 12th century, when Georgia was threatened by Mongol invaders, King Giorgi III (1156–1184) began excavating a fortified monastery within the rocks of the Erusheti Mountain at Vardzia in southern Georgia. The project was completed by his daughter, Tamar the Great. The interconnected caves and tunnels went deep into the mountain over a 1,640-ft (500-m) stretch of the rock face and were supplied with water via a sophisticated irrigation system.

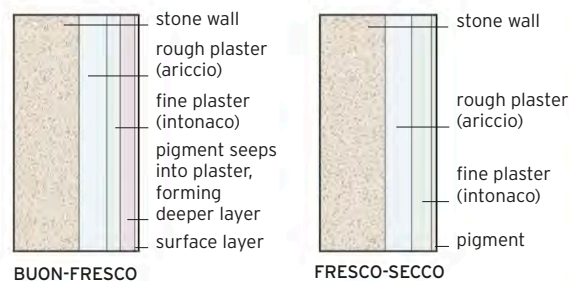
The invisible fortress

When completed, this underground citadel extended to 13 levels and contained some 6,000 apartments, a throne room, and a large church at the center of the complex. The Church of the Dormition was built on the orders of Queen Tamar when she succeeded the throne after her father's death. Hewn into the rock, the church is more remarkable for its mural decorations than its architecture. Paintings on the walls of the church, regarded as some of the finest examples of mural painting of the Georgian golden age (1089–1221), depict scenes from the life of Christ and of the saints, as well as portraits of Tamar and her father.

The greatest defense of the Vardzia monastery was its invisibility: its only entrance was hidden from view, and the system of caves was entirely within the mountain.

FRESCO-SECCO MURAL PAINTING

The murals in the church are painted using a fresco-secco technique, which differs from buon-fresco painting, as the colors are applied to a dry, finished surface rather than to wet plaster. Hence, the pigments form a superficial layer and do not seep into the plaster as they do in a true fresco.



▷ IN PLAIN SIGHT

Once hidden within the mountain, the interior of the monastery was exposed by a rockfall caused by a severe earthquake in 1283. The entrance to the church and the honeycomb of caves and tunnels are now clearly visible on the hillside.



Dambulla Cave Temples

Sri Lanka's largest cave temple complex, containing numerous magnificent Buddha statues and decorated with Buddhist paintings



At the foot of a large rock outcrop near Dambulla, in the hills of central Sri Lanka, is a series of five caves, which were transformed into Buddhist temples over a long period from the 3rd century BCE to the mid-13th century CE. The site, now one of the country's main tourist attractions, is famed for its lavish mural decorations and the collection of more than 150 statues of the Buddha.

Colossal caves

The largest of the caves—Maharaja Lena ("Cave of the Great Kings")—contains 56 Buddha statues, as well as statues of the gods Saman and Vishnu and of the kings Vattagamani Abhaya and Nissanka Malla. A spring reputed to have healing powers trickles into the cave through the ceiling, which is painted with scenes from the life of the Buddha. Although considerably smaller, the neighboring Devaraja Lena ("Cave of the Divine Kings") houses an impressive reclining Buddha statue carved into the rock. To the other side of the Maharaja cave is the Maha Alut Vihara ("Great New Temple"), which takes its name from the comparatively recent 18th-century wall and ceiling paintings of the Buddhist revival period.

TEMPLE ENTRANCES

Although often referred to as a single temple, there are in fact five discrete cave temples in the Dambulla complex. All are approached through a courtyard, and the first three (the major Devaraja, Maharaja, and Maha Alut temples) via doorways in a verandah added in the 1930s. The two lesser temples have separate entrances at the far end of the courtyard.

